

ETHICS IN SOCIAL MEDIA RESEARCH

(SOC 2101 – Society, Environment and Engineering Ethics)

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1. What is Social Media Research

Social media research refers to any research that uses data derived from social media platforms.

- It includes:
 - Using social media as a research tool (surveys, interviews, focus groups)
 - Research on social media activity and content itself
- Why social media data is valuable:
 - Rich source of natural attitudes
 - Reflects real human behavior
 - Large-scale, real-time, and easily accessible

2. Major Areas of Social Media Research

(a) Data Collection

- Data gathered through:
 - interviews
 - focus groups
 - surveys
- Example: Studying diabetes-related Facebook groups to understand emotional support sharing.



(b) Content Analysis

- Social media posts are used as data sources:
 - Facebook posts
 - Tweets
 - YouTube videos
- Example: Analyzing behavioral patterns of drug-addicted young adults on social media.

3. Why Privacy Is Important in Social Media Research

- A person's social media profile can affect:
 - Reputation
 - Life management
 - Freedom of thought and speech
 - Personal and professional opportunities
- Loss of privacy may lead to:
 - harassment
 - discrimination
 - psychological harm
 - psychological harm
 - financial risk

4. Consequences of Social Media Data Leakage

- Leaked social media data can be:
 - exploited by cybercriminals
 - used for impersonation
 - used in social engineering scams
 - used to steal sensitive information (e.g., credit card details)



5. Key Ethical Concerns in Social Media Research

- Private vs Public data
- Informed consent
- Data ownership
- Anonymity
- Risk of harm
- Vulnerable users
- These concerns do not disappear just because data is online.



6. Private vs Public: A Core Ethical Dilemma

- Whether data is public depends on:
 - the platform setting
 - the user's reasonable expectation of privacy
- Important ethical view: Data being accessible does not automatically make its use ethical.
- Examples:
 - Password-protected Facebook group → Private
 - Open Twitter hashtag discussion → More likely public, but still context-dependent
- Researchers must evaluate ethics even for "public" data.

7. Informed Consent in Social Media Research

- Common Mistake: Clicking "Agree to Terms & Services" ≠ informed consent.
- Most users do not read terms and are unaware their data is used for research.
- Informed consent must include:
 - Clear purpose of research
 - Awareness of participation
 - Right to withdraw (right to be forgotten)
- Ethical challenge: Deleting a post/account does not always mean the researcher knows participation has ended.

8. Anonymity

- Anonymity must be ensured unless explicit consent is given.
- Exception: Public figures acting in a public capacity.
- Social media data is searchable and difficult to anonymize.
- Example comparison:
 - Professional photoshoot image → less need for anonymization
 - Protest participant photo → high need for anonymization

9. Risk of Harm

- Higher risk → higher ethical responsibility.
- Consider:
 - vulnerable groups (mental health patients, minors)
 - sensitive topics (suicide, abuse, drug use)
- Key points:
 - Consent from underage participants is not sufficient alone.
 - "Heat of the moment" comments may cause regret later.
 - Live/current data increases harm risk.



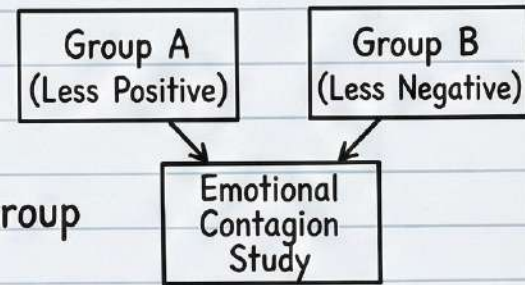
10. Ethical Framework for Social Media Research

- Before conducting or publishing research:
 - Read relevant terms, conditions, and guidelines.
 - Remember T&C can change and may target users or third parties.
- Assess:

☑ [◦ Is the data public? ◦ Are participants young or vulnerable? ◦ Is the data sensitive?	• For republication: ☑ [• Seek informed consent. • Anonymize where needed. • Paraphrase carefully. • Consider copyright issues.
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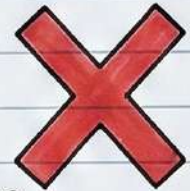
11. Facebook Emotion Study (2012)

- Conducted on 689,000 users.
- Manipulated newsfeed:
 - reduced positive content for one group
 - reduced negative content for another group
- Aim: to study emotional contagion.
- Ethical concerns:
 - No informed consent
 - Emotional manipulation
 - Psychological harm risk
- This case shows how large-scale social media experiments can violate ethics even if data is internal.



13. Common Exam Mistakes to Avoid

- Saying "data is public, so ethical"
- Ignoring informed consent
- Forgetting risk of harm
- Not distinguishing private group vs public figure
- Writing solutions without anonymization or opt-out options



14. Keywords to Remember (Memory Hack)

- Think **P-I-A-R-E-H**

P - Public vs Private

I - Informed consent

A - Anonymity

R - Risk of harm

E - Ethical framework

H - Human vulnerability

15. Likely Question Patterns

- Identify ethical issues in a social media research case.
- Is this data public or private? Justify.
- How should informed consent be ensured?
- What risks of harm exist and how to reduce them?
- Compare two case scenarios (private forum vs public figure).



Good Luck!



CASE STUDY 1: Mental Health Support Forum

Context (as given in slide)

- A researcher wants to study how members of a mental health support forum support each other.
- Topics include depression and suicidal thoughts.
- The forum is private and has a forum administrator.
- Members share highly sensitive personal experiences.



Ethical Concerns (write in points, expand in exam)

Exam Tip: Explain points in detail!

- Expectation of privacy Members joined a private forum expecting confidentiality.
- Sensitive and vulnerable population Mental health, depression, suicidal thoughts → high vulnerability.
- Informed consent missing Members did not agree to participate in research.
- Risk of psychological harm Exposure or misuse of data may worsen mental health.
- Data misuse during reporting Even anonymized quotes may be traceable.



Ethical Solution (VERY IMPORTANT – write stepwise)

Memory Trick: Follow the steps logically!

- Treat all forum data as private data, not public.
- Contact the forum administrator first.
- Use the admin to:
 - ▷ inform members about the research purpose
 - ▷ seek explicit informed consent
- Provide opt-out options:
 - ▷ Members uncomfortable with research must be allowed to withdraw.
 - ▷ They should still be able to use the forum normally.
- For data use:
 - ▷ Use only consented data
 - ▷ Anonymize all personal identifiers
- For republication:
 - ▷ Seek separate informed consent from each member.
 - ▷ Avoid direct quotes if they can lead to identification.



Examiner Keyword Triggers (remember these)

- Private forum
- Vulnerable group
- High risk of harm
- Explicit informed consent
- Anonymization + opt-out



CASE STUDY 2: Olympic Athletes' Social Media Posts

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Context (expanded, exam-strong)



- A researcher intends to study the **tone** and **nature** of social media postings of **Olympic athletes**.

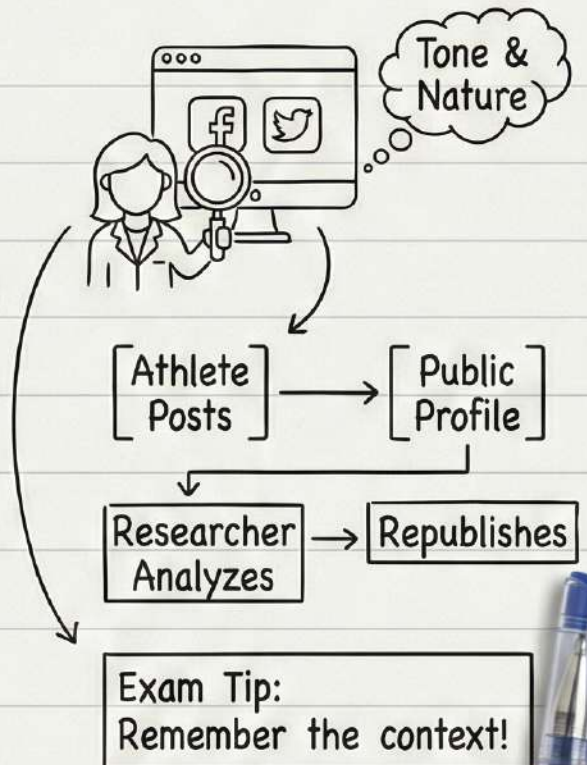
- The research focuses on:
 - language used in posts
 - emotional tone
 - public engagement patterns

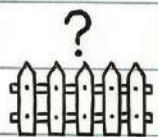
- Data sources include:
 - Facebook profiles
 - Twitter (X) accounts

- These accounts:
 - are **public profiles**
 - have large numbers of followers.
 - are used intentionally to communicate with the public and fans.

- The athletes post content to:
 - express opinions
 - share professional updates
 - engage with audiences

- The researcher wants to republish and analyze these posts as part of the study.





Ethical Concerns (point triggers for exam)

- **Public vs private data boundary**: Whether publicly visible posts are ethically free to use.
- **Context preservation**: Risk of misinterpretation if posts are taken out of context. ↳ Exam Tip: Crucial point!
- **Republication ethics**: Whether posts can be reused without modification or consent.
- **Potential reputational impact**: Risk of unintended harm if analysis is misleading.



Ethical Solution (pointwise, expandable)

- Consider the data as **public data** because:
 - Athletes use public profiles.
 - Purpose of posting is public engagement and visibility.
- **No requirement for anonymization** because:
 - Athletes are **public figures**.
 - Acting in a public capacity.
- Republication is ethically acceptable if:
 - Posts are quoted accurately.
 - Meaning and context are preserved.
- Risk of harm is minimal because:
 - Posts are already widely visible.
 - Research does not reveal private or sensitive information.

Examiner Keyword Anchors

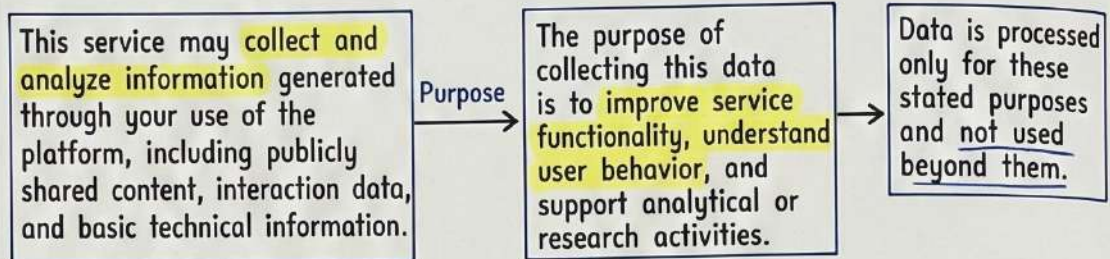
- **Public profile**
- **Public figure**
- **Reasonable expectation of publicity**
- **Context preservation**
- **Low additional harm**



INFORMED CONSENT & TERMS OF PARTICIPATION

(Sample - Exam Answer Format)

Please read these Terms carefully before using this service.
By continuing, you confirm that you **understand and agree** to the conditions described below.



Reasonable steps are taken to protect user privacy. Where possible, collected data is **anonymized and stored securely** to reduce the risk of identification or misuse.

However, data that is already publicly available on social media platforms may not be fully anonymizable.



The service does not intentionally collect highly sensitive personal information unless clearly stated at the time of collection.

PARTICIPATION & RIGHTS

Exam Tip:
Voluntariness
is crucial!

Participation in data collection is **voluntary**. You may stop using the service at any time.

Where technically feasible, you may request that your data no longer be included in future analysis.

Any findings or reports generated from the data will be presented in **aggregated or anonymized form** to minimize the risk of harm to individuals.

AGREEMENT

By agreeing to these Terms, you acknowledge that you have read and understood how your data may be collected and used.

Continued use of the service indicates acceptance of these conditions.

If you do not agree, you should discontinue use of the service.

If you have any questions regarding these Terms or data use practices, you may contact the service provider or research team through the provided contact information.

- ☐ I have read and understood the Terms of Use and Data Consent.
- ☐ I agree to the collection and use of my data as described above.
- ☐ I AGREE ☐ I DO NOT AGREE

Signature (if applicable): _____ Date: _____